directly beside her armored truck. If Benazir had not just bent down inside the steel-shelled vehicle, she would have been killed instantly, as were 179 of her supporters outside the van. She had been warned of possible assassins awaiting her return, but Zulfi Bhutto's daughter had always been fearless, fatalistically believing, "I will be safe until my time is up."

Violence spread across Pakistan in the aftermath of that first attack aimed at Benazir Bhutto, and Musharraf postponed elections scheduled in January for one month. Before year's end, political campaigns were in full swing, however, and it seemed clear from the size of the crowds that gathered to cheer Benazir that she and her father's PPP would be returned to power. After finishing a warmly received speech in Rawalpindi on 27 December 2007, Benazir stood up in her car as it drove out of the crowd and was shot dead by a young assassin, who appears to have acted on orders from Pakistan's arch-terrorist Taliban leader Baitullah Mehsud. No Pakistani could forget, of course, that in the Army Stadium in the same military headquarters city of Rawalpindi, half a century earlier, Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan had been assassinated. Many feared that Benazir's murder would trigger a return to martial rule, but Musharraf had earlier turned over his baton of military command to General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani, a more cautious younger officer, apparently less tempted to usurp political power.

The PPP rode a tidal wave to victory in 2008. Benazir's nineteen-year-old son, Bilawal, was too young to take up her mantle, however, and he returned to Oxford, leaving his father, Asif Ali Zardari, to serve as chairman of the party. Nawaz Sharif, whose Muslim League–Nawaz Party won the second largest block of seats in Islamabad's Assembly, initially agreed to allow several of his party's members to join a PPP-led coalition cabinet in Islamabad. But Nawaz swiftly lost faith in Zardari, who refused to agree to reappoint Iftikhar Chaudhry as chief justice of the Supreme Court, despite his "firm" preelection commitment to do so. Nawaz suspected that Zardari feared that Chaudhry would resurrect charges of corruption against him, possibly even one for the "murder" of Benazir's brother, which had been dropped by Musharraf when he and Benazir agreed to share power. Nawaz was also eager to charge Musharraf himself with high treason for launching his coup against him when he was Pakistan's elected prime minister. Zardari's refusal to agree to Nawaz's demands drove him out of their tenuous coalition, leaving Benazir's widower to run for president himself in September. Though without Nawaz's support, Zardari won the election, in great measure a